

For a young Reddy, the folk and tribal art of India opened up a whole new world of visual influences

exhibition brings together several sculptures made between 2018 and 2026.

At the heart of it is the colossal 'Portrait of Parvati' (2019), presented from both the front and back, allowing viewers to experience the sculpture holistically. New wall-mounted reliefs from 2026 mark a more contemporary direction in Reddy's exploration of sculptural portraiture. Together, the works reflect his signature monumentality, vibrant use of colour and enduring interest in the human form and Indian arts, an artistic language that was not formed overnight.

"When I started studying art, I found it difficult to understand modern art and sculpture," he recalls. He would also wonder why Egyptian and Mexican art could be appreciated internationally while Indian traditions were sometimes dismissed as old-fashioned. His answer lay closer to home. Visits to culturally abundant sites such as Ajanta and Ellora prompted him to study Indian figures and their expressions, while folk and tribal art opened up another world of visual influences. "Over time, these experiences prompted me to develop my own body of work," he says. These echoes of India's artistic traditions continue to find expression in his work. "My main inspirations are my culture and surroundings—what I see around me every day. My work is very deeply rooted in India," he affirms.

This richness, for him, is not just present in the country's museums and monuments but also in its living craft traditions. "India is incredibly rich. The kind of work our ancestors produced is something very few places in the world can match. If you go to Tamil Nadu, for instance, you will find living temples and an extraordinary range of craft traditions, from metal and bronze to stone and wood." He points to the continued presence of these ancient traditions in Karnataka and Kerala too.

Today, he observes, artists are "much more exposed", well-read and technically aware. A growing market, a more connected world and a greater interest in visual art have created more opportunities. "There is a tremendous growth in creativity and the market is supportive too," he says.

For Reddy, however, embracing these advancements does not mean moving away from his roots. *In Search of the Perfect Image* reflects that balance and brings together different moments in his practice, offering viewers a sense of where he has come from and where he may be headed. As he puts it, "This exhibition offers a glimpse of the past, present and future, and perhaps an indication of the direction in which I am moving." ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo

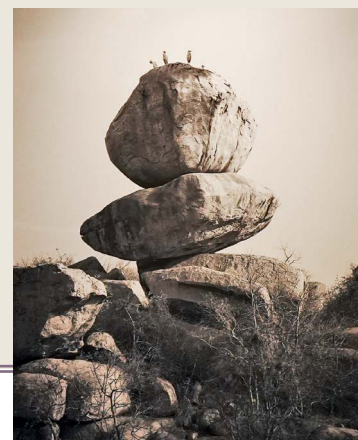
The exhibition is on display at Gallery Sumukha, Bengaluru, till Oct. 3

Renhui found their unique artistic idioms and vocabularies to speak about the same journey. The culmination of that dialogue is now showcased at *Red Rocks, Rivers and Monkeys* at Hampi Art Labs, curated by Yasufumi Nakamori.

"Three years ago, I set foot in Hampi for the first time, and its rich history, architectural remnants and breathtaking natural beauty have lingered in my mind ever since, whether I'm in Japan or the US. The artists' expressions I witnessed and curated have breathed new life into these ancient relics," Nakamori says.

For Zhao Renhui, the residency shifted the way he thinks about landscape. "Rather than approaching Hampi through its monuments or history, I found myself drawn to the quieter relationships between people, animals, water and the land," he says.

THE ARTISTS' INTERACTIONS HAVE RESULTED IN A MEDLEY OF VISUALS OF HAMPI THAT GO FROM THE VISCERAL TO THE SPECTACULAR



His approach, in conversation with Bhalla's more extroverted questioning of their environs, has resulted in a medley of visuals and interpretations of Hampi that go from the visceral to the spectacular. As Bhalla says: "[The collaboration] revealed what happens when different perspectives arrive at multiple answers and possibilities that work towards the same aim of revealing what lies beneath." ■

—Arshia

The exhibition is on display at Hampi Art Labs till Nov. 4